

High-growth in the South West

Mapping out the most ambitious
businesses in the South West of England

What do we mean by “ambitious”?

We use 8 criteria to identify high-growth and ambitious companies. Each of these are a sign of external validation that a business is either actively growing or creating ambitious growth plans.

All companies featured in this report have met at least one of these growth triggers.



Equity investment



Venture debt



Accelerator attendance



Grant recipients



Scaleups



High-growth lists



MBO/MBI



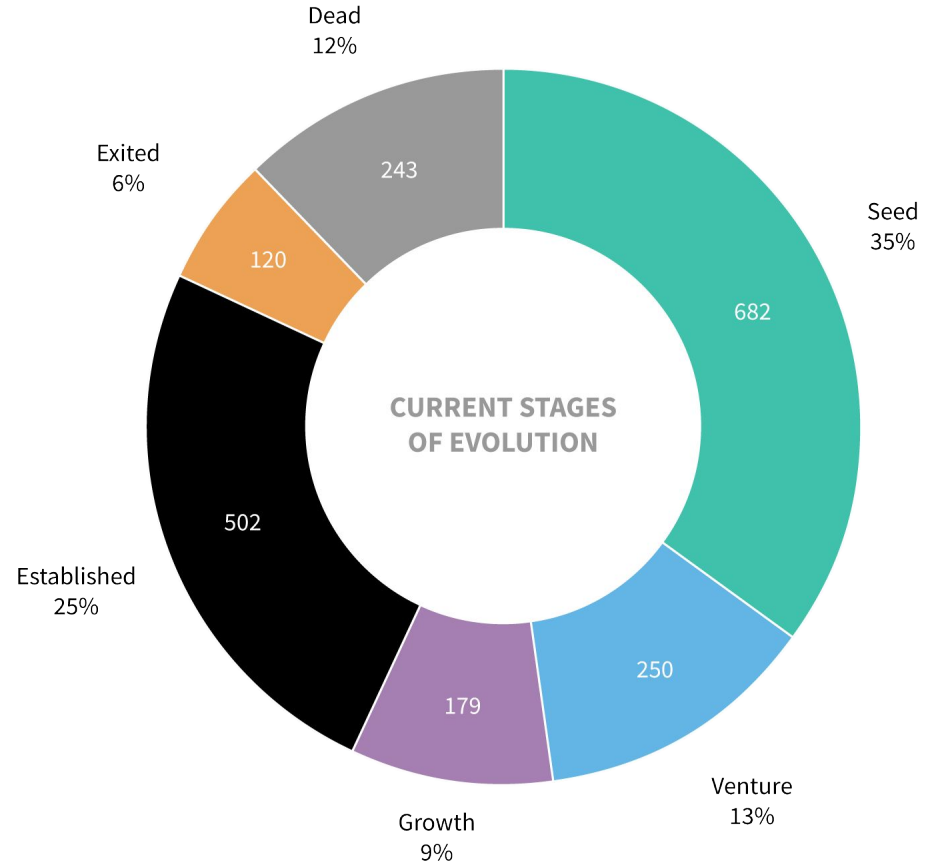
Academic spinouts

Stages of evolution

There are **1613** active, ambitious companies in the South West, **7%** of the UK's total.

Since 2011, an additional **120** have exited the market, either through an IPO or an acquisition, and **243** are no longer trading.

The distribution of stages of evolution in the region is roughly in keeping with the national average.



Methods of growth

51% of high-growth companies in the South West have used equity funding to grow since 2011. This figure varies across the region, with **43%** of companies in Wiltshire using equity to grow, compared to **56%** in Cornwall.

19% have received grants and **17%** have achieved scaleup status.

Raised equity

1015

Visible scaleups

339

Received grants

376

Spun out of a university

69

Attended accelerators

353

Featured on a high-growth list

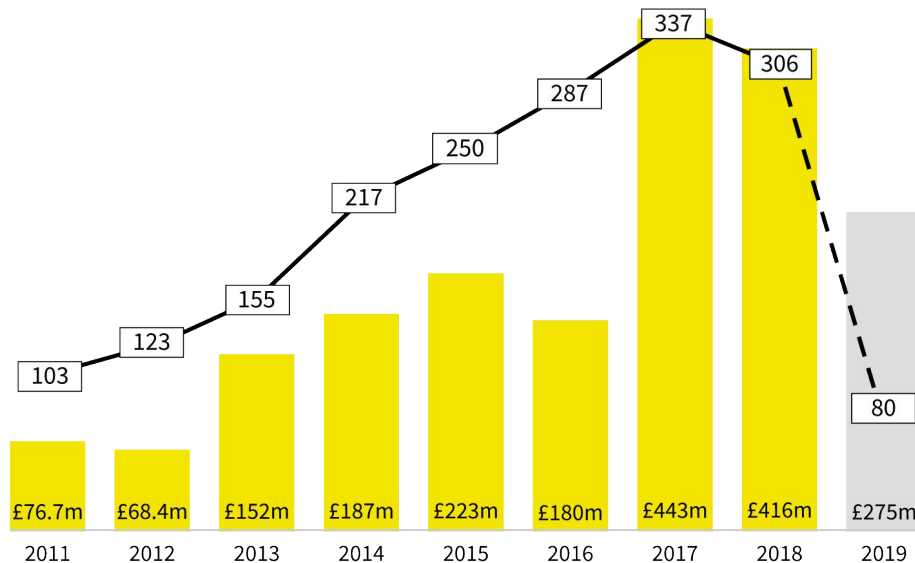
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Fundraising statistics

2019 has already been a stellar year of funding for the South West. The first quarter has been the highest on record, thanks in large part to an injection of **£200m** into Bristol based OVO Energy from Mitsubishi Corporation.

This means that **10%** of the UK's announced equity funding in 2019 so far has gone to companies in the South West.

NUMBER OF DEALS AND AMOUNT RAISED

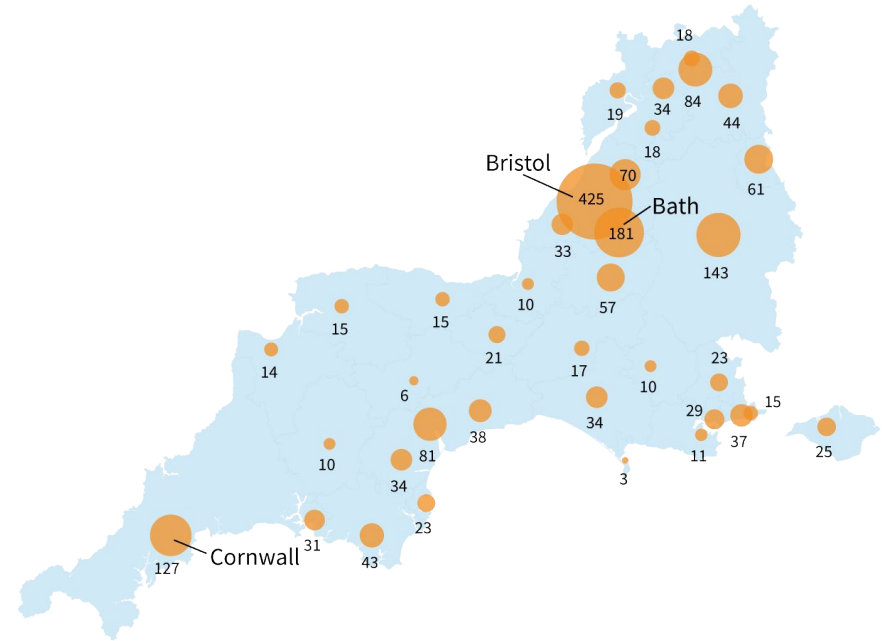


Geographical distribution

The biggest destination for funding is, unsurprisingly, around Bristol and Bath. These cities are home to a number of well funded companies alongside OVO Energy, including semiconductor company Xmos (£43.6m), its AI spinout Graphcore (£244m), and pioneering AR company Ultrahaptics (£74.4m).

This cluster of companies helps make Bristol a leading tech centre in the UK.

NUMBER OF DEALS COMPLETED BY LOCAL AUTHORITIES



Sector focus

There’s also a large investment hub in Cornwall, where the biggest fundraising recipient is Goonhilly Earth Station, having raised a total of **£24.7m**.

GES is part of the Aerohub Enterprise Zone, just one of the developments that upholds the region’s reputation as a centre for Aerospace technology. 30 high-growth aerospace companies in the UK (**15%**) are headquartered in the South West.

BEST FUNDED AEROSPACE COMPANIES IN THE SOUTH WEST

Company	Total raised	Local authority
Goonhilly Earth Station	£24.7m	Cornwall Council
Gilo Industries Group	£13.8m	Wiltshire Council
Boxarr	£4.4m	Bristol City Council
HiETA Technologies	£763k	South Gloucestershire Council
Electroflight	£600k	Cheltenham Borough Council

NUMBER OF HIGH-GROWTH COMPANIES AND DEALS BY LOCAL AUTHORITY

Local authority	Number of high-growth companies	Amount raised since 2011	Number of deals since 2011
Bristol City Council	426	£908.6m	425
Wiltshire Council	156	£194.4m	143
Bath and North East Somerset Council	123	£182.8m	181
Cheltenham Borough Council	58	£131m	84
Cornwall Council	142	£82m	127
Swindon Borough Council	70	£64.3m	61
Exeter City Council	66	£61.5m	81
Borough of Poole	51	£49.9m	29
South Gloucestershire Council	111	£38.8m	70

Local authority	Number of high-growth companies	Amount raised since 2011	Number of deals since 2011
Gloucester City Council	37	£31.0m	34
Plymouth City Council	37	£28.8m	31
Teignbridge District Council	35	£27.2m	34
Tewkesbury Borough Council	33	£26.5m	18
Cotswold District Council	50	£22.6m	44
South Hams District Council	32	£18.9m	43
Mendip District Council	47	£18.8m	57
Bournemouth Borough Council	36	£18.8m	37
East Devon District Council	39	£17.0m	38

NUMBER OF HIGH-GROWTH COMPANIES AND DEALS BY LOCAL AUTHORITY

Local authority	Number of high-growth companies	Amount raised since 2011	Number of deals since 2011
Isle of Scilly Council	21	£12.1m	25
Mid Devon District Council	14	£10.6m	6
North Somerset District Council	65	9.64m	33
North Devon District Council	19	9.40m	15
West Dorset District Council	33	9.06m	34
East Dorset District Council	27	9.04m	23
Torbay Council	25	7.15m	23
Forest of Dean District Council	20	6.41m	19
Christchurch Borough Council	19	3.71m	15

Local authority	Number of high-growth companies	Amount raised since 2011	Number of deals since 2011
Stroud District Council	37	3.06m	18
West Somerset District Council	6	2.71m	15
Taunton Deane District Council	29	2.67m	21
Weymouth and Portland Borough Council	4	2.42m	3
Torridge District Council	13	2.12m	14
North Dorset District Council	17	1.67m	10
West Devon Borough Council	9	1.63m	10
South Somerset District Council	33	1.59m	17
Sedgemoor District Council	26	1.50m	10
Purbeck District Council	10	780k	11

Female Founders

24% of high-growth companies in the South West have a female founder, the second highest rate in England after the North East.

So far in 2019, **20%** of deals in the South West have gone to female founders - the highest on record - but they received just **4%** of pounds invested. This figure increases to 13% if we discount OVO Energy's megadeal.

2013 was the only year in which the average amount raised was higher for female founders than their male counterparts - £1.35m compared to £1.25m.

PERCENT OF DEALS SECURED BY FEMALE FOUNDERS



PERCENT OF TOTAL AMOUNT RAISED BY FEMALE FOUNDERS



Top investors

The top investors are a mix of government backed money, EIS fund managers and patient capital.

BGF tops the list with **10** deals since the start of 2018, the largest of which was an **£11.5m** investment into Cornwall based clothing brand Seasalt.

TOP INVESTORS INTO THE SOUTH WEST BY NUMBER OF DEALS SINCE 2018

BGF	10
Parkwalk Advisors	6
Bristol Private Equity Club	5
Mercia Technologies	3

Top companies by amount of funding raised

Company	Total raised	Sector	Headcount	Stage of evolution
OVO Energy	£259m	Energy utilities services	>1000	Established
Graphcore	£244m	Chips and Processors	100-249	Growth
TrueSpeed	£75.3m	Fixed-line services	50-99	Venture
Ultrahaptics	£74.4m	Hardware, Augmented Reality	100-249	Growth
Binx Health	£75.3m	Clinical diagnostics	50-99	Growth

Top companies by latest pre-money valuation - venture stage*

Company	Latest pre-money valuation	Sector	Headcount	Stage of evolution
MoveGB	£49.7m	Gyms, mobile apps	50-99	Venture
The Mortgage Lender	£39.0m	Consumer banking and financial services	50-99	Venture
Blu Wireless Technology	£36.3m	Chips and processors	50-99	Venture
SRT Marine System Solutions	£35.3m	Marine software	50-99	Venture
Recycling Technologies	£31.1m	Clean energy generation	50-99	Venture

*who have raised investment where we have managed to calculate a valuation

Top companies by growth in turnover 2017 - 2018*

Company	Latest Turnover	Growth from previous	Headcount	Sector	Stage of evolution
Mike Burton	£43.3m	232%	50-99	Business event management	Established
Redcliffe Homes	£26.4m	91%	25-49	Property development	Established
Future Advanced Manufacture	£11.7m	80%	50-99	Engineering	Established
Vapormatt	£6.77m	78%	25-49	Machinery	Established
Mirage Inks	£9.88m	64%	50-99	Packaging and printing	Established

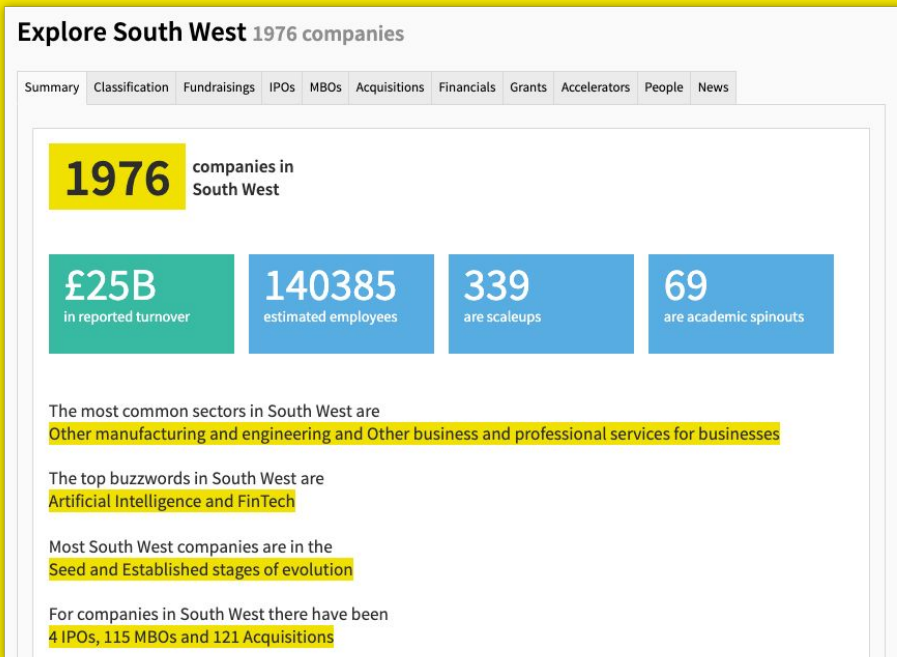
*who have filed full accounts in both 2017 and 2018, where 2017 turnover is at least £100k

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